

Readings

The Imperfectionist

by Rev. Forest Church

The reason I've been able to produce so much
is that I'm not a perfectionist -
I'm an imperfectionist.

I'm confident that everything I say
can be improved upon by others,
and that's my greatest strength,
because I know that it won't be improved up by others,
unless I take the first step.

When we only do things which please us,
or don't frighten us,
after a while fewer and fewer things please us.

Over time, our circle of options diminishes
until we are prisoners in gardens of our own making.

The more decisions you make in your life,
the more times you act,
the more certain it is that you will be wrong.

To be fulfilled we need to recognize,
all of us,
that the world doesn't owe us a living -
rather we owe the world a living.

And in the brief time that is given us,
we must somehow learn to give ourselves away.

Shaky Skaters

by Jane Rzepka

Roller World is a typical roller rink that rents out foul-smelling skates with fragile laces, and then pounds your ears senseless with hard-driving rock music. Roller World caters to people with no standards, no taste, and no class.

Like my family and myself.

I love Roller World. No one was born to skate, but there we all are, a roomful of unlikely skaters, doing our best. A few of course are hot shots, whizzing around on one foot, backwards half the time, breezy as you please. And another bunch, sad to say, is hopeless - their eight little wheels completely ignoring mission control. But round and round the rest of us go, steady and solid, one foot and then the next, in careful time to the Beastie Boys or Twisted Sister.

Folks look pretty darn good out there. I suppose I do, too. No one knows that if even one word is spoken in my direction, I will lose my concentration and hit the floor hard. No one realizes that if they come up behind me too fast, I will panic and crumble into the wall. No one can see that this steady skater is so precarious that the act of skating, just skating, takes everything.

As we roll round the rink, uncertain of our stride and rhythm, may we yet see the instability of those who surround us. May we help when we are steady, holding those who falter; may we calm the reckless and urge the timid forward; may we keep gentle company with the skaters at our side. Let us move with the spirit of love, and may some quiet presence help us with our laces at the end.

The Spirituality Of Mediocrity

Perfectionism is so seductive; it promises so much. Perfectionism whispers satisfaction. It intimates acceptance and control, protection and safety. It compels us with the expectation of fulfillment and happiness. It lies to us.

Our culture exalts perfection. It is venerated to the point of idolatry. Every corporation touts unparalleled customer service. Each school is top notch, every restaurant is fabulous, and all vehicles are outstanding - boasting the J.B. Powers awards for excellence!

From childhood, people are taught the importance of striving to be the best. We are told that if we try hard enough, we can be anything and we can be excellent at it. We just need to set our minds to it. "If something is worth doing, it is worth doing well." To accept anything less than perfect is "settling." Pursuing any goal means aiming for the top, the ultimate. And if, for some reason beyond our control, we can not be the very best, our defense needs to be that we gave it our personal best. Perfection, and striving for perfection have become the measure of our character and moral imperatives. Accept nothing but the best!

The biggest problem with perfectionism is that it is based on faulty thinking. It gives us an illusion of control. If we can do a job perfectly, we will be spared the pain of criticism. If we have no faults or foibles getting in our way, people will like us. If we try hard enough and do it right, we will be satisfied. If we manage it all brilliantly, we will be safe and we will be loved.

There is nothing wrong with wanting to do things well or to be our best. But perfectionism isn't that. On some level, perfectionism is about control and fear. Somehow, we buy into the fallacy that doing a spectacular job will spare us from criticism. Yet most of us have learned that people can always find something to disparage. There is the painful reality that being perfect does not make people like us. Instead, we gravitate to flawed, quirky, and messy people; who, because they are so likable, remind us that we too can be loved with all of our warts.

Excellence gives us no guarantees. When almost everyone and everything are described in superlatives, when fabulous, awesome, magical, brilliant, phenomenal, great, and profound are the words we use for “good,” it is almost impossible to be truly exceptional. In a culture that demands everything be over the top, nothing is over the top. Sort of like getting “A’s” in high school and college, then going to grad school and finding that “A’s” are the expectation. Nothing special here.

A job well done is satisfying. A job done perfectly - is frustrating and exhausting. Albert Bandura, an American - Canadian psychologist explains how difficult it is for a perfectionist to be pleased with their work. The higher a person’s goal, the less chance they have of doing it flawlessly. “Perfect” is not just about the final product. It also means that there are no mistakes, false starts, stumbles, or problems in getting to that final goal. Product and process both have to be irreproachable.

Perfection employs “all or nothing” thinking. The “If...Then” analysis has no wiggle room. “If good parents are loving, kind, balanced, attuned to the needs of the child, wise motivators and disciplinarians, and always there physically and emotionally for their children and I do those things, all the time, then I am a good parent. If I don’t do all those things, all the time, then I am not a good parent. When perfectionists don’t meet their goals, they judge themselves harshly and catastrophize. Instead of questioning the reasonableness of their goals, they question themselves. Instead of backing off, they push harder. The concept of “good enough” is both foreign and scary.

It isn’t a leap to understand the link between believing that if we can manage something, we won’t be surprised or harmed by it. If we can regulate one area of our lives, others could be regulated too. If we can do it all right, we will be alright. All this work, striving for perfection just highlights the spiritual maxim, “We only try to control that which we fear.”

Perfectionism is a catch 22. Psychoanalytic theorist Karen Horney explains that this “tyranny of shoulds” erodes peoples’ self-esteem and their lives. We will never be perfect enough.

Enter Mediocrity. It is not special, outstanding, or stellar. It is average, middle of the road, nothing to write home about. And is a sure path to freedom from perfectionism.

I have a good friend who shared with me that her superpower is "Not to give a flying fig." It has removed so much stress from her life. It's not that she doesn't try to do good work, and she actually does great work, better than most people I know. She has managed to free herself from the impossible mindset that she can always do better. She is living the delightful emancipation from perfectionism to "good enough."

Just explaining the perils of perfectionism to people rarely helps. Telling them about the many ways it is detrimental to their physical, emotional, and spiritual health doesn't make a dent in the struggle to always be better. Arguing that doing something impeccably does not inherently make it, or the person - more valuable, or that statistically, everyone can not be at the top of the class all the time, does not deter people from falsely believing they should be the best. You know what does make a difference? Discovering the joys of mediocrity.

Dr. David Burns, creator of the "Feel Good" approach to treating depression and anxiety, gave his patients the "Pleasure Predicting Sheet." Individuals caught on the hamster wheel of desperately trying to do their best were asked to keep a record. They would write down activities they planned to do. Next to them, using a scale of 1 - 100, they were to predict how much pleasure they expected to experience. After said activity, they rated their own performance, how well did they do, and finally, how much did they enjoy it.

Over and over, people are "shocked to observe that many of the activities they did in an "average" or "below-average" way were among the most rewarding." One physician with "substantial academic accomplishments was ... surprised to learn that they could experience greater personal satisfaction in doing a below-average job of fixing a broken pipe that flooded the kitchen, than in giving an outstanding lecture to a group of medical students." This thoroughly debunked their belief that "they can't experience any pleasure from an activity

unless they perform it in an outstanding manner.” (Psychology Today 1990)

Challenging this “all or nothing” thinking opens avenues previously unimaginable. Who would have thought that lowering their expectations would make life better? Especially in an age where the focus is continually on exceptionality! Research repeatedly demonstrates that when people lower their standards, they are less stressed, frustrated, and anxious. One perfectionistic high school principal was having trouble sticking to his jogging routine; he began to dread jogging. It was suggested that instead of trying to run further, he should consider his jogging done for the day if he ran a quarter of a mile, instead of his usual five to ten miles. “Anything beyond that would be gravy - optional running for pure pleasure. He also agreed that every subsequent day, he was to run one-half the distance he had run the day before. Not making gains, but going backward. He reported that as a result of these modest and backward goals, his aversion and anxiety disappeared and he was able to adhere to his fitness program consistently.

“The same strategy, he reported, improved his outlook and productivity at work. He found it surprising that the lower he set his standards, the greater his output became and the more satisfaction he experienced....he was able to improve his output substantially. It struck him as odd that as he began to aim to [become] increasingly “average,” other people seemed increasingly impressed. Eventually he gave up his perfectionism entirely and became addicted, he said, to the idea of being average.” (Psychology Today 1990)

It is a novel idea that a task does not have to be done perfectly, it just needs to be completed. That good enough really is “good enough.” I’ve always found it encouraging that in the Hebrew and Christian creation story, God created the world and at the end of each day declared that it was “good.” On the sixth day, when the world was

complete, God said it was "*very good*." According to the scriptures, God said "very good" - not "perfect."

It turns out that mediocrity, average, ordinary, common place and middling are beneficial for self-esteem. Since a perfectionist is never satisfied, allowing oneself to be pleased with "OK" removes the need to perform. Trading impossible standards and expectations for lower ones may, or may not, decrease the quality of our performance. In return for letting go of perfectionism, we gain more freedom, flexibility and opportunities for joy and creativity - less compulsion and constraint, more independence and room to move.

Chances are, I haven't given you any earth shattering news today. I can even admit with some irony that this sermon is mediocre. Let's take this one step further. So far, mediocre has carried the connotation of average. Mediocre can also mean sub-par. It can be just in the middle, or it can be lower, second-rate, inferior, shoddy. Here is where the spirituality moves to a whole new level.

What if - what if we made the decision to be dull, tacky, or just plain bad? Now, as a minister, I'm not preaching about lowering your moral and ethical standards. However, do you realize how much audacity it takes to be unapologetically lousy at something?

How many times have we opted out of an activity or a class because we didn't want to look bad? We avoid being the beginner. It is uncomfortable and perhaps vulnerable. Our pride keeps us from trying something new. Or, if we can resist our desire to always be decent at what we do, we can hold on to the caveat that we are just learning. We'll get better over time. If we can't be perfect, we can always be working to improve.

When I was doing research for this sermon, over and over it became clear that mediocrity is not okay! It is a sin! It is complacency. It is giving up! In all of the books, articles, Ted talks, podcasts, and religious materials I examined, there was a resounding declaration that we have an obligation to be the best we can be! Life is too precious to be lived in mediocrity. Success is striving to live up to one's potential.

The correlating chant to this voice is that most people are too fearful to move beyond the common and average. It requires courage and fortitude to be extraordinary. Those who are content to stay where they are are inferior to those brave souls who move into the realm of excellence and magnificence. It is proclaimed one could accept mediocrity only if it is there as an immutable fact. Average is palatable only when there is no other choice. It is not OK for mediocrity to be the goal.

I beg to differ. The individual who is not shamed by charges of complacency, or withered by the calls of cowardness - is pretty secure in their own skin. Because society's obsession with perfection dictates that we have to always give it our personal best, deciding to do anything in an average manner is where the real bravery comes in. This is an act of faith. - To truly believe so much in the inherent worth and dignity of every human that one no longer feels the need to prove their value - now *that* is a statement.

It is also an act of humility. True humility is all about what is as grounded as the earth - "humus." Not bragging and not playing down, just honoring what is.

What if someone has the goal of playing the saxophone abysmally? What would it mean if someone aspired to dance awkwardly, write crappy poetry, and then move on to god-awful wood work? What would it say about living up to their potential if people tried things out, did them ineptly, and then either continued to do them clumsily, or move on to some new thing to do egregiously?

Could it be that the "less than mediocre" mediocrity is a path to mindfulness - allowing oneself to be present in the here and now, without the underlying plan of gaining mastery? When children play, we don't ask, "How did you do?" We want to know "Did you have fun?"

In a world that screams we always need to do better - doing a shoddy job just for the joy of doing something, is a small and powerful act of resistance. It isn't far from Frederick Buechner's definition of Grace:

It is something you can never get,

*but only be given.
There's nothing YOU have to do.
There's nothing you HAVE to do.
There's nothing you have to DO.
You just reach out and take it.*

Welcoming the pedestrian, uninspired, the schlocky and the cheesy aspects of our lives without insisting on improvement may be one of the most intrepid acts of faith we can manage. It is acting on the conviction that we are worthy of respect and dignity. Period. It gives us a solid spiritual base.

There is a great story in Rachel Naomi Remen's book "Kitchen Table Wisdom." Here she writes about one of her patients.

"This patient had Chronic Fatigue Syndrome and spent several years seeking help for her symptoms. She would go from doctor to doctor 'obsessed with the minutest details of her physical problems, which she tracked in a daily journal.' She thought she had to be without symptoms to enjoy life, to go to the theater, to have children, to love. It seemed to her that life could only be lived by the well.

Then in meditation one day, she saw that her chronic disease was not stopping her from participating in life; rather, it was the meaning she assigned to that illness. She was surprised to find that there was absolutely no reason why — if she felt weak or was in some pain — she couldn't still go to the theater. It might take her longer to get to her seat and if she felt poorly she may have to leave early and miss the last act. But otherwise, operating from the way in which she defined her illness, she would have missed the whole play."

Today, Dr. Remen writes: *"She has stopped pursuing the perfect health she once had and does what she can to strengthen her body in simple, natural ways. Instead of seeing four or five doctors a week, she now consults her doctors only for serious problems. She has discovered that by being willing to begin without being certain of the*

outcome, she is often able to do a great deal more than she would have thought. Laughingly, she says that she has made a substitution in the cross-stitched sampler that hangs in the walls of her inner life. It used to say, 'Life is only for the well.' Now it says, 'Anything worth doing, is worth doing half-baked!'" (adapted)

One last consideration to the spirituality of mediocrity is the Japanese practice of Wabi-Sabi. It is seeing and celebrating the beauty in what is flawed or worn. It is the opposite of favoring shiny and new. "According to the Japanese legend, a young man named Sen no Rikyu sought to learn the elaborate set of customs known as the Way of Tea. He went to tea-master, Takeeno Joo, who tested the younger man by asking him to tend the garden. Rikyu cleaned up debris and raked the ground until it was perfect, then scrutinized the immaculate gardens. Before presenting his work to the master, he shook a cherry tree, causing a few flowers to spill randomly onto the ground....Rikyu understood to his core that there is beauty in imperfection and profundity in earthiness.... As a single idea, Wabi-Sabi fuses two moods seamlessly; a sigh of gentle melancholy and a sigh of slightly bittersweet contentment, awareness of the transience of earthly things and a resigned pleasure in simple things that bear the marks of that transience...It depends on the ability to slow down, to shift the balance from doing to being, to appreciating rather than perfecting." (Unte Reader 2001)

The spirituality of mediocrity offers emancipation from the "tyranny of the shoulds" and the never-ending drive for perfection. It exposes the illusion of control, inviting us to experience life more fully. It calls for a more authentic humility. It refutes the mantra that "amazing" is the new "average." "Complacency" can also be "content."

Embracing our own mediocrity, when it is straddling the middle - and when it is on the lower side of inadequacy - demonstrates our faith in our 2nd UU principle - the inherent worth and dignity of every human being. Honoring the unexceptional for other people exudes

grace for everyone. It is a radical dance, declaring that worth is not earned.

Spiritual mediocrity encourages us to abandon our pride and delight in play. Nothing has to be mastered to prove ourselves valuable. Nothing has to be done well to be enjoyed. And contrary to all that consumerism would tell us, there is beauty and loveliness in something well used, just as it is.

May we have the courage to ignore the internal and external demands for excellence.

May we worship by entering into new experiences with low expectations.

May we revel in the joy of comfortably doing things badly.

May we have the faith to aspire to be average.

May we embrace the freedom of knowing in our bones, that we are enough.

Amen and Amen

